

Exploring Resistance and Other Oppositional Responses to AI

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Abstract

This workshop will gather researchers and practitioners who study, and/or engage in, opposition to the proliferation of AI technologies. It will do so based on an inclusive conceptualization of what counts as AI, thereby assembling a diverse collection of participants and perspectives. The organizers will especially solicit submissions that respond to a variety of specific themes: resistance in *organizational contexts*; understandings of *community-based collective* resistance; research around *non-voluntary* adoption; considerations around *distributions of power* in the creation and use of AI; implications for *designing technologies* to support opposition, and the possibility of *resistance indirectly reifying* current conceptions of AI. Prospective participants will be invited to submit descriptions of their work either studying or engaging in oppositional practices, as well as a challenge they have faced in doing so. The workshop will involve a series of interactive, hands-on activities to enable participants to share both challenges and strategies. In addition to catalyzing connections among researchers, the workshop will also produce two concrete outputs: a living annotated bibliography of relevant citations across diverse domains, and a practical guide with context-sensitive tactics for challenging the perceived inevitability of AI.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing;**

Keywords

resistance, opposition, non-use, AI

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*Organizers are listed alphabetically by last name.

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1 Introduction

Not everyone is equally enthused about the massive surge in the development and deployment of AI (“artificial intelligence”) technologies. Various groups have formulated guidance, norms, and policies that constrain how AI should be used (if at all), from professional journalists [27], to scientific researchers [13], to screen writers and entertainment industry studios [39].

Despite instances of such resistance, contemporary sociotechnical imaginaries assume a form of inevitability about these kinds of tools. For example, OpenAI has operated on the assumption that (super)human-level AI is inevitable [8, 28], and that the only way to have any control is to be the ones making it. That is, although AI is a human-created phenomenon, no individual or group seems to have the power to say “Yes” or “No” to AI.

Part of the goal, then, both in this workshop itself and in the work it aims to advance, is finding means of collectively organizing to figure out how we do actually have a choice. This workshop will create a space for discussing those responses to AI (broadly construed) that are less than sanguine about its societal prospects. Beyond challenging the “solutionism” of AI [30], such responses may take a variety of forms, including but not limited to: resistance, avoidance, irritation, protest, friction, dissidence, subterfuge, alterity, or even destruction. These kinds of responses may occur in a wide range of application domains, from professional software development, to higher education, to creative pursuits, to many others.

2 What is AI?

Suchman [37] and others have warned against the “thingness” of AI, i.e., presuming a singular system or ontological agent in the world. Thus, rather than articulate a single definition, this workshop will accommodate varied approaches to construing AI.

Traditionally “AI” is defined as “the study of how to make computers do things at which, at the moment, people are better” [31] [see also 25]. Such definitions inherit much from the prototype of Turing’s imitation game [38] with respect to aping human characteristics and interactions. Other conceptualizations emphasize specific functions. For instance, Narayanan and Kapoor [26] suggest that AI can be conceived of in terms of three main types: prediction, which anticipates future events (e.g., recidivism risk assessments [3]); generation, which creates synthetic content (e.g., “deepfake” videos); and content moderation, which makes curatorial decisions (e.g., recommender systems).

As a counterpoint, Crawford [10] suggests that AI is not purely or even primarily a technical phenomenon, but a materialist-performative enterprise enacted across global networks of power. Artificial intelligence is neither intelligent, because “the very concept of intelligence is a construct of cultural systems among humans” [23], nor artificial, because it is “made from natural resources, fuel, human labor, infrastructures, logistics, histories and classifications” [10, p. 8].

For the purposes of this workshop, then, we take an expansive view of “AI(s).” We invite workshop participants who see themselves and/or their work as resonant with the themes described below to articulate those resonances in their own terms.

3 Workshop Themes

The workshop’s themes, described below, both connect with prior research and suggest opportunities that future work could pursue.

3.1 Organizational Contexts

In professional settings, workers constantly navigate the intersection of personal values, professional responsibilities, and organizational demands [24]. This local interplay among various sociotechnical forces can precipitate opposition and resistance. Foundational CSCW research demonstrates how resistance to technologies can arise from misalignment among these forces [29]. In recent work, UX professionals chose not to use AI due to personal preferences for manual design, a sense of professional responsibility regarding user data and AI-generated outputs, and adherence to organizational policies and regulations [9].

Such sociotechnical factors are neither static nor discrete—they are fluid, interconnected, and constantly evolving [34]. Non-use within organizational settings is thus multi-dimensional and dynamic, operating simultaneously at individual, organizational, and societal levels. We invite submissions that describe opposition to AI in such organizational contexts, especially how opposition to AI both resembles and differs from opposition to other sociotechnical arrangements.

3.2 Community-Based Collective Resistance

Practices of non-use, resistance, and disruption often occur through forms of collective action. Zong and Matias [41] highlight the multiplicity of collective-based practices that can be used to challenge AI and data-oriented systems. For instance, enumerating a set of collective principles, such as the Feminist Data Manifest-No, can identify a set of practices that researchers should refuse and commitments for how researchers should interact with data subjects in ways that embody an alternate set of politics [15]. Other approaches utilize the development of new social computing systems, such as efforts to facilitate collective action among people demanding new data practices and privacy protections [40] through a form of computer supported collective action [33]. Community-oriented practices highlight new sites and moments of intervention beyond immediate technology design and use, such as Krafft et al.’s toolkit that supports community audits of local municipalities’ AI policies and AI acquisition processes [21].

We invite submissions that consider how CSCW approaches to challenging AI may build on or support these diverse collective-based practices, in particular noting the breadth of potential modes and sites of intervention.

3.3 Non-voluntary Adoption

Prior work on technology non-use suggests there may be situations where a user reports being required (perhaps even forced) to use a technology against their will [4, 36], such as an individual who needs to maintain a social media account to fulfill professional responsibilities [5]. With AI, such situations occur with increasing frequency. For instance, Overleaf, the collaborative LaTeX editor used to draft this workshop proposal, recently integrated LLM-based writing and editing features. While Overleaf allows users to disable these features¹, not all instances of AI can be so easily avoided.

However, research on non-volitional technology use remains fairly sparse. Thus, we invite submissions from researchers studying situations of mandated, coerced, or otherwise forced “adoption” of AI technologies.

3.4 Human Labor and Distributions of Power

We are also concerned with themes related to the broader global contexts of AI systems, including human labor, distributions of power and capital, and material resources. Gray and Suri [16] describe the human infrastructure of AI in micro-tasks, and Shestakofsky [35] explains how such a division of labor is the result of the growth requirements of venture capital. Both Crawford [10] and Crawford and Joler [11] highlight how AI also involves complex material supply networks. We therefore welcome submissions from those whose resistance communities involve more expansive definitions of “AI” systems with respect to environment, labor, global cultures, materials, and forms of capital.

3.5 Implications for Design

Qualitative CSCW papers often include a section on “implications for design” [14]. Usually, these offer suggestions for how designers could modify existing technologies, or create new technologies, to better support users in accomplishing their work. Such suggestions may fall flat if they conflict with the profit motives of technology companies. Moreover, suggestions for building “better” AI do not make sense for critics who believe the entire enterprise of AI is fundamentally harmful [e.g., 2].

However, this does not mean that design cannot be a resistance strategy. Technologies can be designed to support individuals and collectives in the work of opposing AI proliferation. For instance, there is an increasing volume and variety of technologies to support Internet users in withholding data, such as TrackMeNot [18], AdNauseam [19, 20], the Onion Router [12], and others. We also acknowledge that alternative AI implementations can constitute a form of resistance, and we invite submissions that describe applied work or critical practice along such lines [cf. 1].

Many of the emerging technologies in this space are not developed by for-profit companies. For instance, Mozilla and Signal

¹[https://www.overleaf.com/learn/how-to/Writefull_integration#How_to_disable_\(switch_off\)_Overleaf%E2%80%99s_Writefull_integration](https://www.overleaf.com/learn/how-to/Writefull_integration#How_to_disable_(switch_off)_Overleaf%E2%80%99s_Writefull_integration).

are both non-profit foundations. Much as computer security researchers regularly engage with industry partners when exposing and remedying vulnerabilities, we invite submissions that explore opportunities for CSCW and HCI researchers to work with the groups and organizations developing these technologies.

3.6 Resistance and Reification

It is possible that opposition and resistance may indirectly reinforce AI as a prefigured entity. Foundational theoretical work describes how critique can, at times, be subsumed into, and thus negated by, the thing being critiqued [22]. For example, a subversive film that critiques the movie industry is still produced by, and thus embedded within, the very system it aims to critique [cf. 17].

In a similar way, the very act of challenging, questioning, or resisting AI may further reinforce the perception of AI as a dominant force. “Asserting AI’s status as controversial [...] without challenging prevailing assumptions regarding its singular and autonomous nature, risks closing debate regarding its ontological status and the bases for its agency” [37, p. 4]. Indeed, critiques of AI may be co-opted and transformed into motivations for efforts to make AI more human-centered. Thus, this workshop encourages submissions not only that involve resistance to systems or to ideologies, but also that challenge the very status of AI as a distinct kind of entity.

4 Workshop Logistics

4.1 Participant Recruitment and Selection

Potential participants, both researchers and practitioners, will be invited (via mailing lists, social media posts, etc.) to submit a short (500~1000 word) position paper describing how their background, experience, and/or interests align with one or more workshop themes. In the position paper, each submitter should include:

- One of the following:
 - one methodological approach or a specific **method for studying resistance to AI** that they have found useful; *OR*
 - one example of a situation where they have **engaged in AI resistance** of some type, along with what happened; as well as
- one **challenge or difficulty** they have encountered in doing this kind of work.

We will select up to 30 participants based on: how their position papers speak to the central themes of the workshop proposal; how likely their responses are to promote discussion during the workshop; and assembling a diverse set of perspectives and approaches.

4.2 Workshop Objectives

- Building a shared community of researchers interested in oppositional responses to AI, facilitating new connections and new potential collaborations.
- Sharing stories and experiences of oppositional responses to AI and creating a shared awareness of the work occurring in this space.
- Reflecting critically on the dimensions where oppositional responses to AI can occur. For instance, who can engage in these practices, how, when, where, and on what terms?

- Generating a shared set of resources and artifacts for researchers working in this area (see Section 4.4 Outcomes for more detail).

4.3 Workshop Activities

We will hold the workshop in-person at CSCW. If a sufficient number of accepted authors (more than about 10%~15%) would prefer, then we will offer a hybrid attendance option. This will include a video stream of group discussions; remote attendees will be consulted to see which video and/or chat platform(s) best supports their accessibility and participation needs. We will designate one of the co-organizers to be a point person for online attendees. This co-organizer will monitor the online channels to facilitate interactions among in-person and hybrid participants, as well as with the CSCW 2025 Accessibility Co-Chairs if needed.

The day will be split into four main time slots, as described below, scheduled around two coffee breaks (one mid-morning, one mid-afternoon), as well as a midday lunch break. During each time slot, one or more organizers will coordinate activities.

4.3.1 Early Morning: Participant Panel. Coordinator: Baumer

- 9:00-9:30 — Welcome
Introductory remarks from workshop organizers.
- 9:30-10:15 — Participant Panel
As organizers, we will invite three to four workshop participants to compose a panel. Panelists will be asked to prepare brief comments sharing whatever highlights they see fit from their position paper.
- 10:15-10:30 — Identify Discussion Topics
Based on this opening panel, workshop participants will identify discussion topics for the Late Morning session.

4.3.2 Late Morning: Small Group Discussions. Coordinator: Wong

- 11:00-12:00 — Small Group Discussions
Based on the Discussion Topics identified in the Early Morning, participants will break into small “birds of a feather” groups and discuss themes of shared interest, with the Workshop Themes from Section 3 as backup breakout group topics. We will run two 30-minute rounds of discussion to allow participants to discuss multiple themes and interact with more people.
- 12:00-12:30 — Reporting Back
We will ask participants to share their reflections and insights from the small group discussions. We will use these reflections to start creating a shared collective notes and resources document.

4.3.3 Early Afternoon: Mapping Exercise. Coordinator: Steup

- 14:00-15:10 — Mapping the Landscapes
In this session, workshop participants will work in groups to “map” the landscape of AI. This exercise is inspired by Crawford and Joler’s *Anatomy of an AI System* [11], which uses the Amazon Echo as a case study to open up the “black box” of AI. We share their goal “to grasp its [the AI system’s] immensity and complexity as a connected form.” Rather than exposing the material costs and unfair labor relations of

AI, though, our focus will be on finding potential points of resistance—levers that could be pulled to affect the seemingly inevitable course of AI development and adoption.

Each group will choose an AI system (e.g., ChatGPT) or domain (e.g., education) and create a corresponding map. Maps may include data and training pipelines, user interaction flows, locations of data centers and energy resources, supply chains, or anything else a group deems relevant. These maps will be used to scaffold the discussion of resistance strategies in the following session.

- 15:10-15:30 — Summaries and Highlights

Each group will provide a brief overview of the map that they created, which will help scaffold the Late Afternoon activities.

4.3.4 Late Afternoon: Strategizing and Planning. Coordinators: Cha and Khovanskaya

- 16:00-16:45 — Identifying Points of Resistance

Workshop participants will use the outcomes from the mapping exercise above to identify points of potential opposition. Groups will be shuffled, both to allow participants to work in different groups and to allow each participant to explore a different map than the one they helped create.

- 16:45-17:00 — Sharing Points of Resistance

Each small group will briefly highlight some of the ideas for resistance that their group identified, along with some of the resources that would be necessary to study and/or to enact that resistance.

- 17:00-17:30 — Looking Forward

The day will end with an unconference-style session. Participants will be asked to suggest ideas for next steps that could be planned. They will then organize themselves into groups, based on what planning they would like to help contribute to.

4.4 Outcomes

This workshop will generate a range of collaborative outputs to support ongoing conversations and actions around AI resistance in diverse contexts. Throughout the day, participants will contribute to a living annotated bibliography that curates key citations, foundational texts, and emerging scholarship on oppositional responses to and critical engagement with AI. In parallel, we will develop a practical guide offering context-sensitive and pluralistic strategies for practitioners and researchers, including actionable tactics for navigating situations where AI adoption is framed as inevitable, such as under organizational or administrative pressures. These resources will be shared afterward on the workshop website².

5 Equipment and Supplies

The organizers request that the conference provide a meeting room with a projector (with HDMI cable for connection) and screen, as well as multiple round tables with chairs.

²<https://oppositiontoai.wordpress.com/>

6 Organizers

Eric P. S. Baumer is Associate Professor of Information at the University of Toronto. His research examines sociocultural dynamics around natural language technologies and other algorithmic systems, including the non-use of social media [e.g., 5–7, 32, 36].

Inha Cha is a Ph.D. student in Digital Media at Georgia Institute of Technology. Her research explores the sociotechnical dynamics shaping AI adoption, resistance, and deliberation in professional settings [e.g., 9].

Vera Khovanskaya is Assistant Professor of Information at the University of Toronto. She studies the role of data tools and technical expertise in workers advocacy organizations, including barriers to worker-centered and community-driven technology design.

Rosemary Steup is a Postdoctoral Scholar in the Computer Science department at Lehigh University. Her research explores the role of computing technologies in people's search for sustainable and meaningful work.

Janet Vertesi is Associate Professor of Sociology at Princeton University, where she is also Associate Director of the Keller Center for Innovation in Engineering Education with responsibility for leading a design program. A longtime conscientious objector to the personal data economy, Vertesi's CSCW research and practice concerns remote collaboration among robotic spacecraft teams at NASA and strategies and technologies for tech resistance.

Richmond Y. Wong is an Assistant Professor of Digital Media at the Georgia Institute of Technology. His research examines how social values of technology are surfaced and addressed in organizational settings, including through practices of non-use, alternative use, or refusal [e.g., 9].

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